Sunday, November 1, 2026
Solemnity of All Saints

St. Bernard of Clairvaux

Abbot, Doctor of the Church · Feast, August 20



San Bernardo, Juan Correa de Vivar, 16th century, Museo del Prado[1]

1. Juan Correa de Vivar, *San Bernardo*, oil on panel, 16th century, Museo del Prado, Madrid.

The first entry in the series falls on the Solemnity of All Saints, the day the Church honors every saint in heaven, both canonized and unknown. St. Bernard opens the series because the Office of Readings for today is his Sermon 2 for All Saints.[2]

✠ The Essentials

- **Origin:** Fontaines, near Dijon, in Burgundy (France). He was the third of seven children of Tescelin, lord of Fontaines, and Aleth of Montbard.[3]
- **Born:** 1090[4]
- **Died:** 1153, at Clairvaux Abbey, a natural death. The Catholic Encyclopedia gives the date as August 21, 1153.[5] His feast is kept on August 20.[6] The harsh early years at Clairvaux had damaged his health.[7]
- **Canonized:** January 18, 1174, by Pope Alexander III.[8]
- **Doctor of the Church:** named by Pope Pius VIII.[9] Pope Pius XII's 1953 encyclical *Doctor Mellifluus* calls him "the last of the Fathers."[10]

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2. Bernard of Clairvaux, Sermon 2 for All Saints, in *The Liturgy of the Hours*, Office of Readings, November 1 (ICEL translation); Latin text in *Sancti Bernardi Opera*, ed. J. Leclercq and H. Rochais, vol. 5 (Rome: Editiones Cistercienses, 1968), 364–68.
3. Marie Gildas, "St. Bernard of Clairvaux," in *The Catholic Encyclopedia*, vol. 2 (New York: Robert Appleton Company, 1907).
4. Ibid.
5. Ibid.
6. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), Proper of Saints, August 20, Saint Bernard.
7. Gildas, "St. Bernard of Clairvaux."
8. Ibid.
9. Ibid.
10. Pius XII, encyclical letter *Doctor Mellifluus* (May 24, 1953), no. 1, quoting Jean Mabillon, preface to *Sancti Bernardi Opera*.

✠ His Life in Brief

Bernard and thirty young noblemen of Burgundy sought admission to the new monastery of Cîteaux.[11] On June 25, 1115, he founded Clairvaux and became its abbot.[12] He founded 163 monasteries across Europe. By the time he died, the houses connected to him numbered 343.[13] He was a monk who wanted only silence, but he became the conscience of Europe:

- When the papal schism of 1130 set Innocent II against Anacletus II, Bernard decided in favor of Innocent II.[14]
- He confronted Peter Abelard's teaching at the council the Pope called at Sens.[15]
- He wrote *On Consideration* for Pope Eugene III, his former monk. Its central idea is that reform of the Church "ought to commence with the sanctity of the head."[16]
- He preached the Second Crusade at Vézelay in 1146.[17]

He explained the Song of Songs in 86 sermons.[18] Dante made him his last guide through heaven in the *Divine Comedy*, and gives him the prayer to the Virgin at the start of *Paradiso* 33.[19]

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11. Gildas, "St. Bernard of Clairvaux."
12. Ibid.
13. Ibid.
14. Ibid.
15. Ibid.
16. Ibid.
17. Ibid.
18. Ibid.
19. Dante Alighieri, *Paradiso*, cantos 31–33; the prayer to the Virgin is 33.1–39.

✠ Famous Excerpt: from his Sermon 2 for the Feast of All Saints (Office of Readings, Nov. 1)

> *"Why should our praise and glorification, or even the celebration of this feast day mean anything to the saints? What do they care about earthly honours when their heavenly Father honours them by fulfilling the faithful promise of the Son? What does our commendation mean to them? The saints have no need of honour from us; neither does our devotion add the slightest thing to what is theirs. Clearly, if we venerate their memory, it serves us, not them. But I tell you, when I think of them, I feel myself inflamed by a tremendous yearning.*
>
> *Calling the saints to mind inspires, or rather arouses in us, above all else, a longing to enjoy their company, so desirable in itself. We long to share in the citizenship of heaven, to dwell with the spirits of the blessed, to join the assembly of patriarchs, the ranks of the prophets, the council of apostles, the great host of martyrs, the noble company of confessors and the choir of virgins. In short, we long to be united in happiness with all the saints."*[20]

✠ 1. Catechesis

Lesson: the communion of saints and the four degrees of love. The excerpt above makes a good introduction to the Church's teaching on the communion of saints (CCC 946–962).[21] For a second lesson, use Bernard's *On Loving God*. In it he describes four degrees of love:[22]

20. Bernard, Sermon 2 for All Saints.
21. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), nos. 946–962.
22. Bernard of Clairvaux, *On Loving God* (*De diligendo Deo*), chs. VIII–X.

1. "man loves himself for his own sake"[23]
2. "to love God, not for God's sake, but selfishly"[24]
3. "to love God on His own account, solely because He is God"[25]
4. man "does not even love self save for God's sake"[26]

His key line: *"the reason for loving God is God Himself; and the measure of love due to Him is immeasurable love."*[27] Ask students which step they are on, and what would move them to the next one.

✠ 2. Apologetics

Objection: "Catholics worship the saints." Bernard's own words answer this. The saints "have no need of honour from us… if we venerate their memory, it serves us, not them."[28] Catholic theology distinguishes the honor given to the saints (*dulia*) from the worship given to God alone (*latria*).[29] The Catechism teaches that the saints intercede for us (CCC 956).[30] It also teaches that remembering them joins us more closely to Christ (CCC 957).[31] Scripture points the same way:

- Hebrews 11 to 12:1: the "cloud of witnesses"
- James 5:16: the prayer of the righteous
- Revelation 5:8: the prayers of the holy ones

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23. Bernard of Clairvaux, *On Loving God* (*De diligendo Deo*), ch. XV.
24. Ibid.
25. Bernard of Clairvaux, *On Loving God* (*De diligendo Deo*), ch. IX.
26. Bernard of Clairvaux, *On Loving God* (*De diligendo Deo*), ch. X, title.
27. Bernard of Clairvaux, *On Loving God* (*De diligendo Deo*), ch. I.
28. Bernard, Sermon 2 for All Saints.
29. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa Theologiae* II-II, q. 103, a. 3.
30. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 956.
31. *Catechism of the Catholic Church*, 2nd ed. (Vatican City: Libreria Editrice Vaticana, 1997), no. 957.

- Mark 12:27: God is the God of the living

Objection: "The Church never reforms itself." Bernard is a counterexample. He insisted that the Church's reform "ought to commence with the sanctity of the head."[32] He wrote his *Apology* in a controversy with Cluny over monastic life.[33] One point should be stated plainly: the Second Crusade he preached failed, and the blame fell on him.[34] He answered with an apology to the Pope, which he placed in the second part of *On Consideration*.[35] A saint is a sinner made holy, not a man who was never wrong. Admitting this makes our case more credible.

✠ 3. Theology

- **Grace and free will:** *"Take away free will and there remaineth nothing to be saved; take away grace and there is no means whereby it can be saved"* (*Concerning Grace and Free Will*).[36] He holds grace and free will together, a both/and that matters for the later Reformation debates.
- **Mariology and development of doctrine:** Bernard called Mary an "aqueduct of grace."[37] Yet in his Letter 174 to the canons of Lyon, he objected to their new feast of Mary's conception.[38] Pius IX solemnly defined the Immaculate Conception in 1854.[39] This shows the development of doctrine that Newman des-

32. Gildas, "St. Bernard of Clairvaux."
33. Ibid.
34. Ibid.
35. Ibid.
36. Bernard of Clairvaux, *Concerning Grace and Free Will*, trans. Watkin W. Williams (London: SPCK, 1920), ch. 1, p. 5.
37. Bernard of Clairvaux, Sermon on the Nativity of the Blessed Virgin Mary ("The Aqueduct"), in J.-P. Migne, *Patrologia Latina*, vol. 183, col. 437ff.
38. Bernard of Clairvaux, Letter 174, to the Canons of Lyons (c. 1140).
39. Pius IX, apostolic constitution *Ineffabilis Deus* (December 8, 1854).

cribed: the Church's understanding can grow clearer over time, even past the views of a Doctor of the Church.[40]

- **Faith and reason:** At the Council of Sens he challenged Abelard's teaching. The Pope confirmed the council's judgment.[41]

✠ 4. Devotional Prayer

Lectio divina: Pray with Bernard's "Star of the Sea" passage, which the Church uses in the Liturgy of the Hours:

"If the winds of temptation engulf you, if you are running onto the rocks of adversity, depend upon the star, call upon Mary... In danger; in distress, in doubt, reflect upon Mary, call upon Mary. Let her not leave your lips, let her not leave your heart..."
[42]

The Memorare: This prayer is often attributed to St. Bernard, but he did not compose it. Fr. Claude Bernard (1588–1641) popularized it.[43] Pray it today alongside his writings on Mary.

Collect for the Solemnity of All Saints (Roman Missal):[44]
Almighty ever-living God, by whose gift we venerate in one celebration the merits of all the Saints, bestow on us, we pray, through the prayers of so many intercessors, an abundance of the reconciliation with you for which we earnestly long. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and

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40. John Henry Newman, *An Essay on the Development of Christian Doctrine* (London, 1845; rev. ed. 1878).
41. Gildas, "St. Bernard of Clairvaux."
42. Bernard of Clairvaux, *In Praise of the Virgin Mother*, Homily 2.17, in *The Liturgy of the Hours*, Office of Readings for the Blessed Virgin Mary, Star of the Sea (Washington, DC: USCCB).
43. "Did St. Bernard Compose the Memorare Prayer?" *Aleteia*, August 20, 2022.
44. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), Proper of Saints, November 1, All Saints, Collect.

reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever. Amen.

Collect for the Memorial of St. Bernard (Roman Missal, August 20):[45]

O God, who made the Abbot Saint Bernard a man consumed with zeal for your house and a light shining and burning in your Church, grant, through his intercession, that we may be on fire with the same spirit and walk always as children of the light. Through our Lord Jesus Christ, your Son, who lives and reigns with you in the unity of the Holy Spirit, God, for ever and ever. Amen.

✠ Today's Takeaway

We honor the saints not because they need it, but because we need them. Bernard's own words make the point: "if we venerate their memory, it serves us, not them."[46]

All Saints, pray for us. St. Bernard, pray for us.

45. *The Roman Missal*, 3rd typical ed., English trans. (ICEL, 2011), Proper of Saints, August 20, Saint Bernard, Collect.
46. Bernard, Sermon 2 for All Saints.